

Φιλόστρατος ὁ Ἀθηναῖος

Sophists, Athletes, and Heroes in Philostratus the Athenian

eul_aid: rfi

Period: [Ῥωμαϊκή](#) [Roman](#)
Dialect: [Ἀττικίζουσα λογοτεχνική](#) [Atticizing Literary](#)
Domain: [Ῥητορική](#) [Oratory](#)
Format: [Λόγος](#) [Oration](#)

Philostratus the Athenian was a Greek orator and author active in the Roman Empire during the late second to mid-third century CE. He was a prominent member of the Second Sophistic, a movement focused on reviving classical Greek rhetoric and culture. Born on the island of Lemnos, he was closely associated with Athens and studied under his uncle, the more famous sophist Philostratus the Elder. He moved within the intellectual circles of the imperial court in the early third century.

His literary output includes several works, though their attribution among various authors named Philostratus is often complex and disputed. According to modern scholars, his most securely attributed surviving work is a second series of **Imagines**, a collection of vivid descriptions of paintings intended as a sequel to his uncle's work. Another significant text probably by him is the **Heroicus**, a dialogue exploring the cult of Homeric heroes. Other extant works, including a dialogue called **Nero**, a collection of **Love Letters**, and a treatise on athletics called the **Gymnasticus**, are of uncertain and debated attribution.

Philostratus the Athenian's significance lies in his contribution to the sophistic literature of his era. His writings exemplify the period's Atticizing style and its preoccupation with education and the creative reinterpretation of classical Greek heritage. His works on art and hero cults provide valuable insights into ancient cultural criticism and the reception of mythology during the Roman Imperial period. While his individual legacy is complicated by authorship uncertainties, his surviving texts represent an important strand of early third-century Greek intellectual life.

Works (7)

- [Τὰ ἐξ τὸν Τυανέα Ἀπολλώνιον](#) · [Apollonius of Tyana's Life](#) · 388 passages
- [Ἐπίγραμμα](#) · [Epigram](#) · 8 passages
- [Γυμναστικός](#) · [Gymnastics](#) · 55 passages
- [Ἡρωικός](#) · [Heroicus](#) · 94 passages
- [Ἐπιστολαί. Διαλέξεις](#) · [Letters, Lectures](#) · 76 passages
- [Βίοι Σοφιστῶν](#) · [Lives of the Sophists](#) · 152 passages
- [Νέρων](#) · [Nero](#) · 7 passages